



A FREE GUIDE FROM MOVING TO LONDON

Know the Differences: Canada vs. UK

The ten places a Canadian home-buying instinct will mislead you in England & Wales — offers, mortgages, surveys, legal work, taxes, and what "leasehold" actually means — set out side by side with what you already know from home.

10 stages compared

BC ↔ England & Wales

Plain English

01 Who's Actually on Your Side

02 Making an Offer

03 Chains, Gazumping & Gazundering

04 Mortgages as a Non-Resident

05 The Survey Nobody Requires

06 The Legal Process

07 Exchange of Contracts

08 Completion & Moving Day

09 Stamp Duty & Total Costs

10 Leasehold vs. Strata



Moving to **London**

Move to London without the guesswork.

Why this guide exists

If you're buying property in England & Wales after buying in British Columbia, the biggest risk isn't a language barrier — it's a false-familiarity barrier. Rightmove looks like Realtor.ca. An "accepted offer" sounds like an accepted offer. It isn't. The ten pages that follow line up each stage of a UK purchase against its nearest BC equivalent, so nothing catches you by surprise at the moment it matters most.

This guide covers England & Wales — the system almost every relocating Canadian buyer will meet. Scotland and Northern Ireland run different legal systems entirely (Scotland's offers are binding within days via solicitors' "missives," for instance), so if you're looking there specifically, treat this as background only and ask your advisor about the local rules.

What's inside

- | | |
|---|--|
| 01 Who's Actually on Your Side — estate agents & buying agents | 02 Making an Offer — and what "accepted" really means |
| 03 Chains, Gazumping & Gazundering | 04 Mortgages as a Non-Resident |
| 05 The Survey Nobody Requires | 06 The Legal Process — conveyancing |
| 07 Exchange of Contracts | 08 Completion & Moving Day |
| 09 Stamp Duty & Total Costs | 10 Leasehold vs. Strata |

Quick glossary — UK terms you'll meet immediately

Flat

What Canadians call an apartment or condo unit — almost always leasehold in England & Wales.

Estate agent

The UK's Realtor®-equivalent, but representing the seller only by default.

Solicitor / conveyancer

Handles the legal transfer — a multi-week process of its own, not a single closing-day signature.

Freehold

Outright ownership of land and building — the rough equivalent of BC fee-simple ownership.

EPC

Energy Performance Certificate — a mandatory A–G rating every seller must provide by law.

Removal firm

Movers — the company that physically moves your belongings.

01 Who's Actually on Your Side

Estate agents & buying agents

In England & Wales, the agent listing a property works for the **seller** — full stop. There's no MLS-style system where agents cooperate on a shared commission. If you want someone representing you, you hire a buying agent separately, and it's worth doing before you view anything seriously.

TOPIC	IN BC	IN ENGLAND & WALES
Licensing	Agents must be licensed through BCFSa before trading at all.	No licence or exam is legally required to call yourself an estate agent or buying agent.
Who they represent	Buyer agency is standard, set out in a written agreement.	The listing agent represents the seller only, by default — no duty to you exists unless you hire your own.
Listings	CREA's MLS — one shared, cooperative database.	Rightmove & Zoopla are paid ad portals, not a shared cooperative system.

DID YOU KNOW

Anyone can call themselves an "estate agent" in England & Wales — no licence, exam or regulator required. Reputable firms instead join a voluntary scheme like The Property Ombudsman.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Without your own buying agent, nobody in the deal is working for you.
- There's no cooling-off period once a verbal offer is accepted.

02 Making an Offer

What "accepted" really means

An accepted offer here is a green light to start spending money on lawyers and surveys — not a firm deal. In BC, subject removal is close to done. In England & Wales, either side can walk away, penalty-free, for months afterward.

TOPIC	IN BC	IN ENGLAND & WALES
Offer format	Written contract with subject clauses (financing, inspection, title) and firm deadlines.	Verbal or informal email through the estate agent — no standard contract yet.
Deposit at offer	A deposit cheque typically accompanies the offer, held in trust.	None required — no funds move at this stage.
Binding point	Days after offer, once subjects are removed.	Exchange of contracts — commonly 6–12 weeks after acceptance.

DID YOU KNOW

Because nothing binds until exchange, roughly **one in four** agreed sales in England & Wales falls through before completion.

SEND WITH YOUR WRITTEN OFFER

- Price, proof of funds, and a Decision in Principle (a soft, non-binding lending estimate)
- What's included: built-ins stay by default, but curtains, appliances & furniture don't unless you ask

03 Chains, Gazumping & Gazundering

Risk that lives in the gap between offer and exchange

Because nothing binds until exchange, England & Wales carries two risks with no real BC parallel — a seller taking a better offer after accepting yours ("gazumping"), and a linked chain of sales where one weak link can collapse everyone's move.

TOPIC	IN BC	IN ENGLAND & WALES
Chains	Delay usually traces to financing on an individual closing date.	Most sales link several buyers and sellers into one dependent chain.
Recourse pre-exchange	Withdrawing after subject removal forfeits the deposit.	Essentially none — either side can walk away penalty-free.
Fall-through rate	Materially lower once subjects are removed.	About 1 in 4 agreed sales collapses before completion.

DID YOU KNOW

"Gazundering" is the buyer's mirror version of gazumping — cutting the offer right before exchange, when the seller has little recourse. Both are entirely legal.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Being chain-free (cash, first-time buyer) is a genuine selling point — say so in your offer
- Home buyers protection insurance reimburses survey/legal costs, not the lost property itself

04 Mortgages as a Non-Resident

Financing gets harder the moment you're not a UK taxpayer

The mechanics look familiar. What changes is how much harder it gets once you're not a UK tax resident — which is most relocating buyers. Deposit requirements roughly triple and the lender list shrinks to a handful of specialists.

TOPIC	IN BC	IN ENGLAND & WALES
Deposit, non-resident	35% minimum for non-residents; no default-insured options.	Commonly 25–40%, capped loan-to-value around 75–85%.
Lender pool	Most major banks will lend to non-residents.	A short specialist list — HSBC UK, Skipton International, NatWest International, Barclays among them.
Pre-approval	Rate-held pre-approval, valid 90–120 days.	Decision in Principle (DIP) — a soft-checked estimate only, not a commitment.

DID YOU KNOW

A UK mortgage valuation exists purely to protect the lender's loan — it is not, and was never meant to be, a survey of the property for you.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Budget 25–40% down as a non-resident, not the 5–10% headline figures
- Use a whole-of-market broker with genuine access to non-resident lenders

05 The Survey Nobody Requires

Property condition checks

Unlike a BC subject-to-inspection clause, nothing requires a UK buyer to commission a survey at all. Many first-time buyers skip it, rely on the lender's valuation alone, and find out about problems only after they already own the place.

TOPIC	IN BC	IN ENGLAND & WALES
Requirement	Subject-to-inspection is close to standard in a firm offer.	Entirely optional, buyer-initiated — no standard clause requires it.
Who conducts it	A licensed home inspector.	An RICS-regulated chartered surveyor.
Report format	Varies by inspector, no standard levels.	Standardized Level 1 / 2 / 3, with traffic-light condition ratings.

DID YOU KNOW

Level 3 (Building Survey) — the most detailed option — exists specifically for older, altered or unusual properties, exactly the kind many relocators fall in love with.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Get results back before exchange — after that, it's bought as seen
- New builds still need an independent snagging inspection, separate from any RICS survey

06 The Legal Process

Conveyancing — searches, enquiries & identity checks

This is the longest, quietest stretch of a UK purchase — typically 8–12 weeks of searches and enquiries between offer acceptance and exchange, and where overseas buyers feel the most friction.

TOPIC	IN BC	IN ENGLAND & WALES
Who handles it	One lawyer or notary per side, typically.	A solicitor or licensed conveyancer per side.
ID / funds checks	Run once, through the brokerage and lawyer.	Agent, lender and solicitor each independently re-verify identity and source of funds.
Overseas buyer rules	Canada currently restricts most non-Canadian residential purchases outright (through Jan 2027).	No equivalent restriction — enhanced due diligence instead.

DID YOU KNOW

With no cross-recognition between parties, an overseas buyer typically submits the *same* proof-of-funds documents three separate times — to the agent, the lender, and the solicitor.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Instruct a solicitor the moment your offer is accepted
- Arrange Power of Attorney early if you can't be in the UK to sign

07 Exchange of Contracts

The moment that finally matches what "accepted" meant back home

Exchange is the point everything has been building toward: solicitors formally swap signed contracts, a completion date is fixed, and — for the first time — withdrawing has real legal consequences.

TOPIC	IN BC	IN ENGLAND & WALES
Binding moment	Subject removal, typically days after offer.	Exchange of contracts, typically weeks to months after offer.
Deposit	Accompanies the offer, held in trust from day one.	Usually 10% (sometimes 5%), transferred at the moment of exchange.
Insurance	Effective from the completion/possession date.	Buyer must have buildings insurance in force <i>from</i> exchange — before they legally own it.

DID YOU KNOW

Risk in the property passes to the buyer at exchange, which is exactly why buildings insurance must be bound that same moment — weeks before legal ownership.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Arrange insurance well ahead of exchange day, not on it
- In a chain, one unready link delays everyone — even a fully ready buyer

08 Completion & Moving Day

A separate day from exchange — sometimes weeks later

Completion is moving day, but in England & Wales it's a distinct calendar event from exchange — which surprises buyers used to one single closing date doing both jobs at once.

TOPIC	IN BC	IN ENGLAND & WALES
Timing	Closing day is a single event.	Completion follows exchange by 1–4 weeks.
Transfer tax	Paid at registration, as part of closing.	Solicitor files and pays Stamp Duty within 14 days <i>after</i> completion.
Title registration	Effectively immediate via e-filing.	HM Land Registry can lag by weeks or months (ownership is still effective from completion).

DID YOU KNOW

You legally own the property from the moment of completion, even though the official Land Registry record can take weeks or months to catch up administratively.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Keys release once your solicitor confirms funds arrived — not before
- The 14-day stamp duty deadline runs no matter how smoothly moving day goes

09 Stamp Duty & Total Costs

The one part of this system that already feels familiar

Stamp Duty Land Tax is a tiered, marginal-rate transfer tax — structurally the closest thing here to what you already explain every day: BC's Property Transfer Tax.

TOPIC	IN BC	IN ENGLAND & WALES
Standard rates	1% to \$200k · 2% to \$2M · 3% above.	0% to £125k · 2% to £250k · 5% to £925k · 10% to £1.5M · 12% above.
First-time buyer relief	Full/partial PTT exemption below set thresholds.	0% to £300k, then 5% on £300,001–£500,000.
Non-resident surcharge	20% Additional Property Transfer Tax — applies right in Victoria's Capital Regional District.	2% surcharge for under 183 days' UK presence in the prior 12 months.

DID YOU KNOW

BC's own 20% foreign-buyer surcharge — which applies right in Victoria's Capital Regional District — is **ten times higher** than the UK's 2% non-resident rate.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Keeping a home in Canada while buying in the UK likely adds a further 5% surcharge on top
- Budget conveyancing (~£1,500), a survey (~£300–£1,000+), and a broker fee, beyond stamp duty itself

10 Leasehold vs. Strata

Why almost every flat isn't quite owned the way you'd think

Nearly every flat in England & Wales is sold leasehold, not freehold — the single hardest concept to translate for a strata owner, because the words sound similar but work very differently.

TOPIC	IN BC (STRATA)	IN ENGLAND & WALES (LEASEHOLD)
Ownership	Unit owned outright, plus a share of common property — no fixed term.	A fixed-term right to occupy (often 99–999 years); a freeholder owns the building and land.
Recurring charges	One strata fee, no ground rent.	Ground rent <i>and</i> a service charge, often to two different parties.
Term limits	No expiry to manage.	A remaining term under ~80 years causes real mortgage problems.

DID YOU KNOW

Reform is coming — a ground rent cap and a ban on new leasehold flats are moving through Parliament — but as of today, none of it is law yet.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Always confirm freehold vs. leasehold immediately — never assume
- A lease under ~90 years is worth flagging early, before it becomes a costly extension

READY TO START LOOKING?

Ten differences down. One decision left.

Every stage above shares one theme: the UK system rewards buyers who have someone in their corner from the very first viewing — not just at the point of exchange. That's exactly the gap a dedicated buyer's advisor exists to close.

01–02 Agents represent sellers by default; an accepted offer isn't binding for months.

03–04 Chains and non-resident financing add real, planable risk — if you plan for it.

05–06 Surveys are optional and legal work runs 8–12 weeks, both easy to underestimate.

07–08 Exchange, then completion — two separate days, two separate sets of obligations.

09–10 Stamp duty and leasehold terms both look familiar — until the details don't match at all.

Talk to a dedicated buyer's advisor.

London Residential Advisors represents relocators exclusively — built for buyers who expect a real buyer's-agency relationship, not just a listing agent's goodwill.

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